

FSEQ User Manual

Welcome to FSEQ. This sequencer is designed to streamline your drum programming workflow in Ableton Live. I have always preferred the classic step-sequencer workflow for drum programming. It bypasses the unnecessary complexities of a traditional piano roll and provides a much cleaner, more focused overview. The vision behind FSEQ was to pair this fast, intuitive workflow with the massive capabilities of the Ableton Drum Rack. While the Drum Rack is arguably one of the best drum programming tools in the world, it can quickly become cluttered and overwhelming to manage. FSEQ bridges this gap, giving you fast pattern creation backed by the deep power of Ableton Live.

Plus, with full total recall, FSEQ saves seamlessly with your Ableton project. So the next time you open your session, your sequencer opens exactly as you left it.

1. Installation

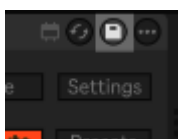
You can place the device in any folder you prefer on your hard drive. It is highly recommended to store it in a folder located within your Ableton Live Browser (Places) so you can easily drag and drop it into your projects.

- **Important:** FSEQ is a MIDI device and must be placed on a **MIDI Track**.
-

2. First Steps

2.1 Settings & Initialization

Before you start producing, it is recommended to adjust the **settings** to fit your workflow and set your preferred **Preset Path** (where your saved patterns will be stored) (see section 5) and **Drumkit Manager Path** (see section 4.4). Once you have configured everything to your liking, save the device itself as an Ableton preset (.adv file). You can save multiple .adv variations with different default settings if needed.



2.2 Main Modes: Drum Rack vs. Manual

FSEQ operates in two primary modes:

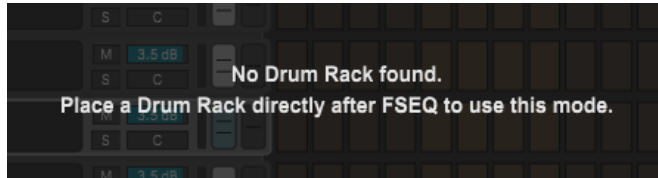
- **Drum Rack Mode:** Designed to work seamlessly with an Ableton Drum Rack. *Note: The Drum Rack must be placed directly after the FSEQ in the device chain.*
- **Manual Mode:** A standalone mode where you can assign custom MIDI notes and row names yourself. It does not require a specific device to follow it.



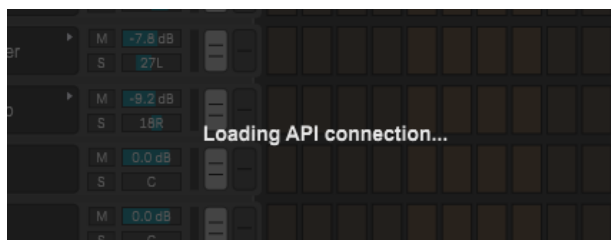
2.3 Drum Rack Mode Integration

When FSEQ is placed on a track, it scans the chain:

- If no Drum Rack is found behind the sequencer, you will receive this message: “No Drum Rack found.”



- If a Drum Rack is added, the API connections will initialize, and you will see: “Loading Api connection...”



Once connected, FSEQ offers **bi-directional control** over the Drum Rack:

- Volume, Pan, Mute, and Solo are fully synced.
- Selecting a row in FSEQ highlights the corresponding pad/chain in the Drum Rack.
- Row names in FSEQ are automatically synced from the Drum Rack pads.
- You can select specific samples via the Instrument Rack Chain Selector (see section 5.2).

3. Creating a Sequence

3.1 Setting Steps

FSEQ is primarily designed for creating drum loops, where each row represents a specific drum sound.

- **Add/Remove:** Left-click on a step in the grid to add a note. Click it again to remove it.
- **Draw:** Click and hold the left mouse button while dragging across the grid to quickly draw or erase multiple steps.
- **Grid Selection:** Right-click and drag to create a selection box in the grid. This can span across multiple rows and is perfect for quickly copying, cutting, pasting, filling, or modifying larger parts of your pattern. This also applies to entire rows (see section 3.3).



3.2 Velocity and Timing Control

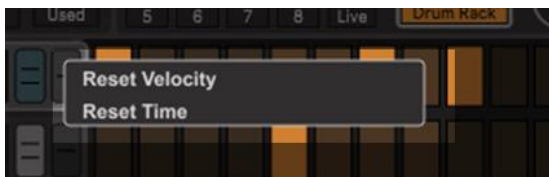
- **Open Expressions window:** Left-click the Expressions button and then the **Velocity** button (or use the scroll wheel while hovering over an active step) to open the velocity window for that row. Each slider represents the velocity of the step directly above it.



Left-click the Expressions button and then the **Time** button (or use the scroll wheel + ctrl while hovering over an active step) to open the Time window for that row. Each slider represents the timing of the step directly above it. Positive values -> move step past the grid, negative values -> move steps post the grid.



- **Adjust:** Click or draw across the sliders to adjust values. Double-clicking a slider resets it to the default value.
- **Reset All:** Right-click the **Expressions** button to instantly reset all velocities or timings in that specific row back to default.



3.3 Managing Rows



- **Selection:** Left-click a row to highlight it. In Drum Rack Mode, this automatically selects the corresponding pad in Ableton. You can also navigate through rows using the **Up** and **Down arrow keys**. Use ctrl + left click to highlight multiple rows. This can be used for auto fills or deleting multiple row content.

- **Row Options:** Located next to the velocity button. Click (left or right) to open a menu with options for automatic standard fills, random fills, copy, cut, and paste. (These functions can also be triggered via Hotkeys).



- **Sample Preview:** Left-click on the row number to trigger a quick audio preview of the sample.

3.4 The Top Bar

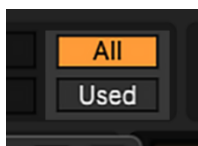
- **Sequence Length:** Set your pattern length to 16, 32, or 64 steps.



- **4x4 Navigator:** Designed to mirror the standard 16-pad view of an Ableton Drum Rack. FSEQ hosts a total of 96 rows (6 pages of 16 rows). Each button in the navigator selects a block of 16 rows. You can also use the **Left** and **Right arrow keys** to switch pages.



- **All / Used:** Toggle your view. "All" shows the standard 4x4 navigator pages. "Used" displays only the rows that contain at least one active step (up to the first 16 used rows), giving you a clean overview of your active groove.



- **Pattern Selection:** Switch between 8 independent patterns. Each pattern saves its own sequence, velocities, and sequence length. Use the **Copy** button to duplicate the currently selected pattern to the next slot for quick variations. **Live Mode** disables the patterns and let you remote control ableton midi clips (see section 3.5).



- **Mode Switch:** Toggle between Drum Rack Mode and Manual Mode.



- **Create Clip:** Exports your current sequence (steps and velocities) into an Ableton MIDI clip.
 - *Place Mode:* The clip is exported to a Session View slot AND instantly placed onto the Arrangement View timeline at your current cursor position.
 - *Clip Mode:* The sequence is only exported to a Session View clip slot.
 - *Tip:* In the settings, you can choose the destination for exported patterns (e.g., the first 8 slots or the last 8 slots of the track).



- **Master Dice:** Picks a Random Sample for every row that contains more than one sample. (see section 4.3)



- **Sample Manager:** Opens the Sample Manager (see section 4.3)



- **Fast Kit Selector:** Loads Drum Kits and Variations without opening the Sample Manager (see section 4.3)



- **Duplicate Length (16x2 / 32x2):** Instantly duplicate a 16-step sequence into a 32-step sequence, or a 32-step into a 64-step sequence with a single click.



3.5 Live Mode

When Live Mode is active, FSEQ will bypass its internal playback engine and act as a remote for the track in which it is loaded. Changes to steps, velocity, and timing will instantly update the selected clip in Ableton. The same applies in reverse.



4. Advanced Sample Selection and Drum Kit Manager

The Advanced Sample Selection and Drum Kit Manager introduces a comprehensive workflow for organizing, saving, and swapping your sounds. This system gives you total control over your sample library directly within the device, ensuring a seamless and creative beat-making process.

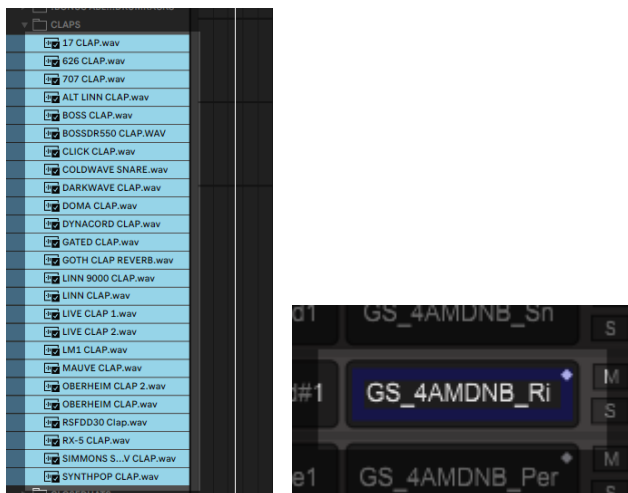
The new method:

This is the default method, which works out-of-the-box without requiring any adjustments to the Multisample settings. The new method was introduced for several key reasons:

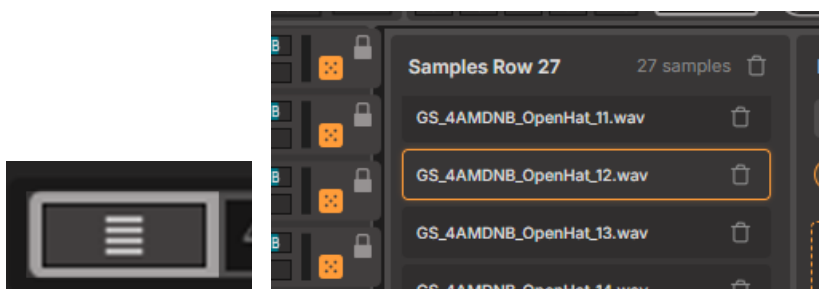
1. It enables the use of the Drum Kit and Sample Manager (which are exclusively available in this mode).
2. It provides a faster and more intuitive workflow for the user.
3. The legacy method was highly RAM-intensive when working with large Drum Racks.

Sample Manager To add multiple samples to the Sample Selector, the target Drum Pad must already contain a loaded instance of **Simpler** (*Note: **Sampler** and **Drum Sampler** devices are not supported for this function*).

Simply **highlight multiple samples** (for instance, within the Ableton Browser) and **drag and drop** them onto the desired **Name Field**. This process can be repeated as needed to add additional blocks of samples.



By **opening the Sample & Drum Kit Manager**, you can easily review all currently loaded samples for a specific Drum Pad. Located on the left side of the interface, the Sample Manager dynamically **displays the samples for the currently selected row**. From here, individual samples can be replaced, removed from the list, or the entire list can be cleared completely. Additionally, samples can be hot-swapped directly within the Grid View (see Section 4.2).



How It Works When a new sample is selected, the active sample within the Simplifier instance is automatically replaced. The underlying sample list is saved in a JSON format that stores the local file paths of the samples on your computer. Because the system references these paths rather than caching the audio data ahead of time, only the samples that are actively loaded into the device consume RAM and CPU resources. This architecture ensures optimal system performance, even when managing large sample libraries.

The old method (still works):

FSEQ utilizes the Chain Selector of an Ableton Instrument Rack nested inside a Drum Rack pad to switch samples. To use this method you have to change the Multisample settings to Chain.

Prerequisites: The Instrument Rack must be the first device in the Drum Pad's chain. Samples must be mapped sequentially from top to bottom in the Chain Selector (e.g., Sample 1 to zone 0-0, Sample 2 to zone 1-1, etc.). *A pre-mapped Instrument Rack containing 128 empty Simplers is included with FSEQ to help you get started.*

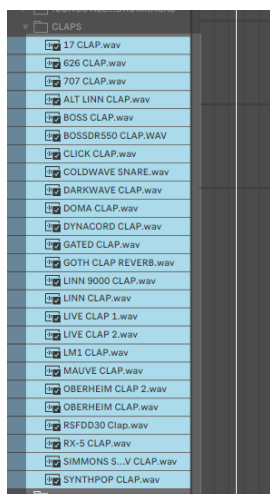
4.1 Building a Multi-Sample Drum Rack

Due to Ableton API limitations, fully automating the creation of Chain Selector zones is not possible. However, FSEQ provides a powerful workflow workaround using the included Simplifier rack:

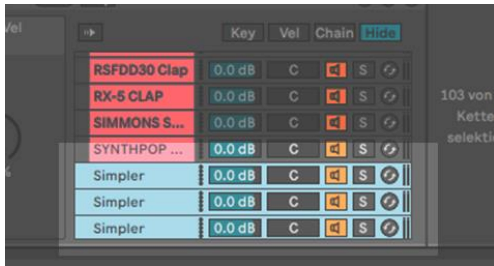
1. Drag the included pre-mapped Instrument Rack onto an empty Drum Pad.



2. Select all the audio samples you want on this pad (e.g., 50 different snares) from your browser, and drag them into the Name field of your choice. The samples will automatically load sequentially into the empty Simplifiers. You can repeat this process to add more samples to the next available slots (up to 128 samples per pad).



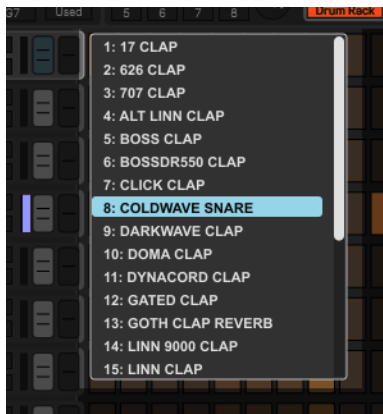
3. **Clean up:** Navigate to the Instrument Rack in Ableton. The used chains will be renamed to your sample names. Scroll down to where the chains are still named "Simpler" (the empty ones), highlight them, and delete them to save RAM.



Tip: Save this completed Drum Rack to your Ableton User Library! You only have to build your ultimate drum kit once.

4.2 Selecting Samples in FSEQ (Grid view)

If a Drum Pad contains a multi-sample setup, a small white arrow will appear in the top-right corner of the FSEQ row name.



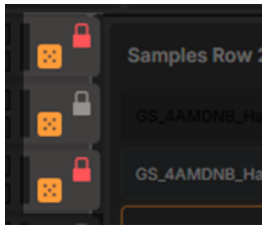
- Left-click the arrow, or right-click anywhere on the name field, to open the **Sample Selection Window**. Click any sample to load it.
- **Fast Scrolling:** Hover over the name field and use your mouse scroll wheel to quickly flip through samples. The selection window will open temporarily to show your position.

4.3 The Dice

Using the **Master Dice**, which is located in the top bar and remains **permanently visible**, you can now select a random sample for each row (i.e., each Drum Pad) simultaneously.



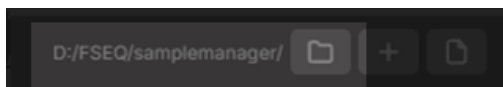
When opening the **Sample & Drum Kit Manager**, you will notice an additional **dice icon and a lock icon on the left side of each row**. The individual dice icon allows you to randomize the sample for that specific row. Conversely, the lock icon **prevents any randomization** for that row, protecting it regardless of whether you click the individual row dice or the global Master Dice.



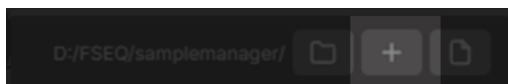
4.4 Drum Kit Manager

The Drum Kit Manager allows you to **save and recall your custom drum kits**, as well as store distinct variations for each kit. These variations essentially save which specific sample is currently active per row. In short, your drum kits contain the pool of multiple samples per pad, while the variations recall a specific combination of those multisamples across the pads.

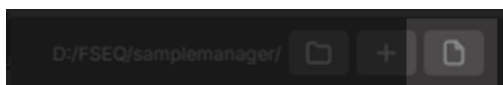
- **Selecting a Folder:** Clicking the folder icon in the top row allows you to define a file path where all drum kits will be saved and loaded from. After choosing a storage location, it is highly recommended to re-save the device within your project (see Section 2.1).



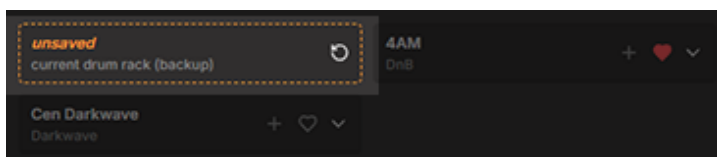
- **Saving a Drum Kit:** Next to the folder icon is a plus (+) button used to create a new drum kit. The currently loaded multisamples are saved as a new JSON file, and the kit will immediately appear in the user interface.



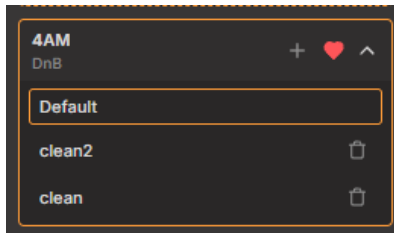
- **Initialize Drum Kit:** This button completely resets the current drum kit. This is useful for starting fresh if samples are already loaded.



- **The "Unsaved" Kit:** The "Unsaved" drum kit functions as an initial snapshot that is captured exactly once when the device is loaded. This provides a safe baseline, allowing you to experiment with your sounds and easily revert to the original state if you are unsatisfied with any subsequent changes.



- **Variations:** Each drum kit also features a plus (+) icon to save new variations. The arrow button expands the drum kit entry to display all existing variations associated with it.

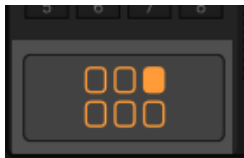


5. Main Device Controls (Track View)

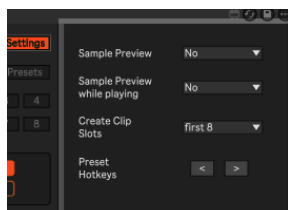
These controls are located on the main FSEQ device interface sitting at the bottom of your Ableton window.



- **Open Sequencer:** Toggles the main floating UI. The button turns yellow/orange when open and white when closed. You can MIDI/Key map this button to toggle the sequencer interface instantly.



- **Create Clip:** Functions exactly like the Create Clip button in the Top Bar. Can be MIDI/Key mapped to export clips while the main UI is closed.
- **Auto Mute:** When enabled, FSEQ monitors incoming MIDI. If a MIDI clip is playing from the Ableton timeline, the sequencer will automatically mute its internal playback to prevent double-triggering.
- **Settings:** Customize your workflow:

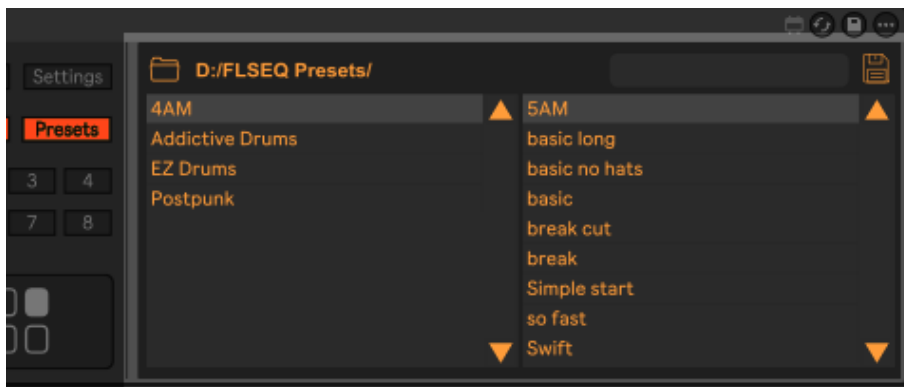


- *Sample Preview (Stop):* Toggles automatic audio preview when scrolling through samples while Ableton playback is stopped.

- *Sample Preview (Play)*: Toggles audio preview while Ableton is playing.
- *Create Clip Slots*: Defines the destination for exported clips.
- *Preset Hotkeys*: Map MIDI/Keys to cycle forward or backward through presets in your selected folder.
- *Multisample Mode*: Swap (new method): Swaps the samples loaded in the simpler device of the drum pad. Chain (old method): uses chain selector to select samples.
- **Presets**: Opens the preset management window.
- **Pattern Buttons**: Mirrors the Top Bar, allowing you to switch patterns while browsing presets.

5.1 The Preset Browser

The left side displays presets; the right side shows your folder structure. Double-click a preset to load it.

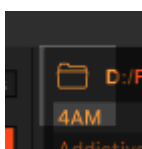


What gets saved in an FSEQ Preset? A preset saves a single pattern (sequence). You can load multiple different presets into the 8 pattern slots of a single FSEQ instance. It saves:

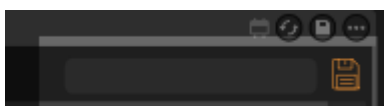
1. The operating Mode (Drum Rack or Manual).
2. Sequence Length (16, 32, or 64 steps).
3. The active grid steps and their velocity values.
4. *Manual Mode only*: Row names and assigned MIDI notes.

Preset Controls:

- **Path Button**: Opens your OS file browser to define your master preset folder.



- **Save Field**: Type your preset name and click **Save** to write the pattern to your hard drive.



6. Keyboard Hotkeys

When a single Row is highlighted (No Grid Selection):

- 1 : Fill every step
- 2 : Fill every 2nd step
- 3 : triplets
- 4 : Fill every 4th step
- Shift + 4: Fill every 4th step (Offbeat)
- 6 : triplets (halftime)
- 8 : Fill Snare pattern
- 9 : Fill Snare pattern (Halftime)
- 5 : Fill Random
- 7 : Fill Random (Dense)
- Arrow Down : Move highlight one row down
- Arrow Up : Move highlight one row up
- Arrow Left : Navigate 4x4 page left
- Arrow Right : Navigate 4x4 page right
- Ctrl + C : Copy entire row
- Ctrl + X : Cut entire row
- Ctrl + V : Paste copied/cut row data
- Ctrl + Arrow Key down : Trigger sample preview
- Delete : Delete row content

When a Grid Area is selected (Right-click drag):

- Ctrl + C : Copy selected steps
 - Ctrl + X : Cut selected steps
 - Ctrl + V : Paste data into selection
 - Ctrl + D : Duplicate selected steps to the next grid position
 - 5 : Random fill within selection
 - 7 : Random fill (Dense) within selection
 - Delete : Delete selection content
-

7. Special Mouse Shortcuts

- **Scroll Wheel over Row Name:** Instantly scrolls through available samples in a multi-sample rack. Opens the sample window for 3 seconds. (If you click a sample or move the scrollbar within this time, the window stays open).
- **Scroll Wheel over Velocity Button:** Opens the velocity window for 1.5 seconds and simultaneously raises/lowers all velocity values for that row at once.
- **Ctrl + Scroll Wheel over Velocity Button:** Opens the velocity window for 1.5 seconds and scales the dynamic range (increases or decreases the ratio between loud and quiet steps).
- **Scroll Wheel over an Active Step:** Opens the velocity window for 1.5 seconds and adjusts the velocity of that specific step. (Clicking inside the window resets the 1.5-second timer).
- **Scroll Wheel + Ctrl over an Active Step:** Opens the time window for 1.5 seconds and adjusts the time of that specific step. (Clicking inside the window resets the 1.5-second timer).
- **Middle Mouse Button over a Row:** Toggles the Solo state for that specific row/drum pad.
- **Left Click + Ctrl on Row Name:** Lets you highlight multiple rows.